told. Some of the accused, including the two Maldivian women had given 'confession statements' under duress, and the statements were videographed. I had the suspicion—which later proved true—that parts of my interrogation were also videographed, though without my consent or knowledge. I had refused to parrot their lines, and this man wanted to make a last ditch effort.

'Before the CBI men question you, here is one more chance for you to tell the truth. What was your deal with Mariam Rasheeda?'

By now I was as tired as them of this game. 'Is it a lie you want to record as a statement? Then record whatever you want and claim I've said it,' I said.

One of them tried to be smart. 'Mariam said that she knows you.'

'Can you bring her here and make her say that?' I challenged.

'What will you do if she says that in front of you?'

'I will slap her.'

They said they have in their custody a Pakistani who had corroborated what Sasi had confessed. They wanted a Muslim name from my mouth to be linked to the imaginary spy tale. I looked at the telephone that was, oddly, in the middle of the room. I knew it had a microphone or a recorder. These men were waiting for me to tell the tale the way they wanted. I decided to have some fun.

'I was approached by one Habibullah in 1982,' I started, and had the immediate attention of my interrogators. 'Well, I think it was 1982 … that's the year you wanted me to say, isn't it?'

They were furious. The recording was being interrupted by the clarification. Every time I built up a tempo, I broke it seeking a clarification about a date. Or I just asked, 'Is that what you wanted me to say?' The officer who I understood to be from R&AW had joined the team midway through the tamasha, and whenever I played the trick he smirked, as if he was getting convinced of my innocence. I am yet to ask him if he knew the truth then.

At this point, someone dashed into the room and said: 'Get ready, we have to move.'